

The Folk Calm Kitchen

25 Chinese Household Healing Traditions

*A Cultural Documentation of
What Families Passed Down Through Generations*

Simmered Preparations . Folk Practices
Grandmother's Remedies from the Chinese Kitchen

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Editorial Boundary

This guide documents household customs and family traditions from Chinese kitchens and communities. It is a cultural record, not a medical text.

The practices described within these pages were passed down through generations -- grandmother to mother, mother to child -- in an oral tradition that predates modern medicine. They are recorded here as cultural heritage, not as treatment recommendations.

Nothing in this guide should be interpreted as medical advice, diagnosis, or prescription. If you have a health concern, please consult a qualified healthcare provider.

The ingredients described may interact with medications or affect existing health conditions. What was safe for one family in one time and place may not be appropriate for another.

Preserve the culture. Consult the doctor.

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Mung Bean Soup (Lv Dou Tang)

Mung bean soup has been a Chinese summer staple for centuries. In traditional understanding, it clears heat and resolves summer heat.

My grandmother's enamel pot came out the first week of June and stayed on the stove until September. One part beans to ten parts water. Bring to a hard boil, then lower the flame. The key to keeping it green: never use an iron pot. A drop of vinegar or lemon juice helps hold the color.

Quick method: freeze washed beans for four hours before cooking. Or soak in boiling water for twenty minutes, or dry-roast for ten minutes. Add rock sugar only in the last five minutes.

Those who tend to feel cold or have loose digestion should go light on this one. Adding a slice of ginger helps balance the cooling nature.

Winter Melon Tea (Dong Gua Cha)

Winter melon tea is not a tea but a concentrated syrup made by slow-cooking winter melon with dark sugar until the cubes turn translucent and the liquid thickens. Stored in a jar in the fridge, it lasts two weeks.

One kilogram of black-skin winter melon. Do not peel it and do not remove the seeds. Three hundred grams of dark brown sugar plus one hundred grams of yellow rock sugar. A few slices of old ginger if your constitution runs cold.

Dice the melon into small cubes. Mix with the sugar and let it rest for thirty minutes to an hour. Bring to a boil, then reduce to the lowest flame and simmer for one to two hours, stirring constantly. When the melon turns glassy and the liquid is syrupy, strain it through a cloth. Into a clean glass jar, into the fridge.

Sour Jujube Seed Tea (Suan Zao Ren Cha)

Sour jujube seed has been used in Chinese households for centuries as a bedtime preparation. The seeds are hard as pebbles and must be cracked open before they release anything useful.

Ten to fifteen grams of seeds. Dry-roast them in a pan over low heat until they turn slightly brown and release a nutty smell. Then crack them open with a rolling pin or mortar. Without breaking the shell, almost nothing transfers into the water.

Soak the cracked seeds in about five hundred milliliters of cold water for half an hour. Then into a clay or ceramic pot (never iron) and bring to a boil. Reduce to the lowest simmer, cover, and let it go for twenty to thirty minutes until the liquid has reduced to about two hundred milliliters. Strain and drink warm, an hour or two before bed.

Chinese Yam Porridge (Shan Yao Zhou)

Shan yao, Chinese yam, specifically the iron-rod variety, is the backbone of what many Chinese grandmothers consider the gentlest food a stomach can receive.

Fifty grams of rice or millet, soaked for half an hour. One iron-rod yam. Peel it wearing gloves because the raw mucilage will make your skin itch fiercely, then cut into chunks. Alternatively, steam the whole yam first, then peel.

Water to rice at eight to one. Bring to a boil, add the rice, and cook for twenty minutes before adding the yam. Then another thirty minutes on low heat until the porridge thickens. Red sugar or goji berries at the end. For babies, mash the yam into a paste and skip the sweetener entirely.

Millet Porridge (Xiao Mi Zhou)

Millet is one of the oldest grains cultivated in northern China, and millet porridge is the first solid food many Chinese babies ever eat.

New millet, harvested within the year, is golden-yellow and smells faintly sweet. Old millet is pale and flat. Wash it gently, two quick rinses, no scrubbing. Soak for twenty to thirty minutes.

Always start with boiling water, cold water makes the millet sink and stick. One part millet to ten or twelve parts water. Bring to a rolling boil for three to five minutes, then drop the heat to the lowest flame and let it murmur for about twenty-five minutes. Stir occasionally. A few drops of cooking oil in the pot keeps it from boiling over.

The best part is the skin that forms on top when you let it rest, the mi you, the rice oil. She would spoon it onto my bowl first, the richest part.

Pear Water (Li Zi Shui)

When a dry cough rattled through the house in winter, my grandmother did not reach for medicine. She reached for a pear. Snow pear, the large, pale-skinned variety with crisp white flesh.

Leave the skin on, wash it thoroughly with salt to remove any wax. The skin holds properties the flesh does not. Remove the core completely, it turns bitter when boiled. Cut into even chunks or thin slices.

Into a clay pot or glass pot, never iron, never aluminum. Water to cover the pear by about two centimeters. Bring to a boil, then reduce to the gentlest simmer. Twenty to thirty minutes, until the pear pieces turn translucent. Add rock sugar, about fifteen to twenty grams per five hundred grams of pear, in the last five minutes. Drink it warm.

She never called it medicine. She just set the bowl on the bedside table and waited for me to finish it.

Lotus Seed and Lily Bulb Soup (Lian Zi Bai He Tang)

Lotus seeds are the pits of the lotus flower, harvested from the seed pod in late summer. Dried, they look like small pale pebbles. Cooked, they turn soft and slightly sweet.

Soak the dried lotus seeds for two to three hours. Remove the green germ in the center of each seed, it is intensely bitter and will ruin the soup if left in. Soak dried lily bulb in warm water for half an hour; fresh lily bulb needs only a rinse and separation into petals.

Lotus seeds go in first. Bring to a boil, then simmer for thirty to forty minutes until they yield to a spoon. Only then add the lily bulb, another ten to fifteen minutes. Lily bulb cooked too long dissolves into paste. Rock sugar at the end. Goji berries go in right before the heat goes off.

Tremella Soup (Yin Er Geng)

Tremella, snow fungus, white wood ear, looks like a pale, desiccated sea creature in its dried form. When soaked and slow-cooked, it releases a gelatinous substance that thickens the liquid into a glossy, almost syrupy soup.

Choose tremella that is slightly yellow and tightly furled, the whiter it is, the more it has been bleached. Soak in cold water for two to four hours, never hot, heat locks the gelatin inside. Once fully rehydrated, cut away the hard yellow base. Then tear the rest into pieces as small as your thumbnail.

One dried head (about twenty grams) to one and a half to two liters of cold water. Bring to a boil, then reduce to the lowest flame for one to two hours. Stir vigorously halfway through. Turn the heat off and let it sit, covered, for twenty minutes, then bring it back to a simmer. Add rock sugar only after the soup has thickened.

She said the soup was ready when it clung to the spoon like it did not want to let go.

Longan and Red Date Tea (Gui Yuan Hong Zao Shui)

Dried longan, the flesh of the fruit, shriveled and dark, tasting of burnt honey, paired with red dates is one of the most common combinations in a Chinese kitchen.

Red dates, pitted. The pit is said to be heating and should be removed. Slice or tear them open so the water reaches the inside. Dried longan flesh, rinsed. Soak both together for twenty to thirty minutes in the water you will use for cooking.

Start with cold water, enough to generously cover the fruit. Bring to a boil, skim any foam, then reduce to the lowest simmer. Fifteen to thirty minutes, the dates should be soft, the longan swollen, the water a deep reddish brown. Add brown sugar or rock sugar in the last five to ten minutes. Goji berries at the very end.

She made this for every woman on the street who had just given birth. A pot of red water, a bowl of red dates, the color of blood returning.

Coix Seed and Adzuki Bean Porridge (Yi Mi Chi Xiao Dou Zhou)

The most misunderstood porridge in Chinese folk tradition. The beans are not red beans, they are adzuki beans, smaller, darker, and more elongated. And the grain is not barley but Coix seed, coix seed. Regular red beans do not have the same property; regular barley does not have the same effect.

Equal parts Coix seed and adzuki beans. The Coix seed should be dry-roasted until slightly golden, this reduces their cooling nature. Soak both for two to six hours.

Plenty of water, the surface should be five centimeters above the grains. Bring to a boil, skim, then simmer for forty minutes to an hour. The adzuki beans should split open; the Coix seed should be soft and swollen. A little rock sugar at the end. Do not add rice, rice introduces dampness.

She told me, with unusual sharpness: Never put rice in that pot. I asked why. She said, Because then it is just breakfast.

Ginger Fever Patch (Jiang Pian Tui Re)

An old household method: two thin slices of raw ginger, placed on the inside of both wrists directly over the pulse point. A small amount of cold medicine powder pressed onto the ginger. Secured with adhesive tape or a strip of cloth. Leave it for about ten minutes.

When a fever spiked in the middle of the night and the clinic was closed, this was what my grandmother did. She cut the ginger, crushed the tablet, and wrapped both my wrists in silence.

This was a household custom practiced before antipyretics were widely available in rural China. It reflects resourcefulness, not medical efficacy.

Alum for Breathing Difficulty (Bai Fan Zhi Chuan)

Three to five grams of alum, potassium aluminum sulfate, crushed into powder and dissolved in about fifty milliliters of boiled water. Administered slowly, in small sips.

This was a measure used in emergencies, for someone who could not catch their breath, who was turning pale, who was panicking. In rural households far from any hospital, having something that could be done was itself a form of comfort.

CRITICAL WARNING: Alum is an astringent compound. Ingestion carries significant risks and should never be attempted outside of qualified supervision. This entry is for cultural documentation only.

Rice Vinegar for Hiccups (Mi Cu Zhi E)

Ten to twenty milliliters of plain rice vinegar, swallowed in one quick motion.

A sharp, sour swallow that shocks the diaphragm into stillness. My grandmother kept a small bottle of rice vinegar in the kitchen specifically for this, not the large bottle she cooked with, but a smaller one with a pour spout, always within reach of the dining table.

She would pour a capful, hand it to whoever was hiccuping, and say: Quick, do not think about it. The surprise of the sourness, combined with the act of swallowing without hesitation, was enough to interrupt the spasm.

She said hiccups are just the body forgetting how to breathe. Vinegar reminds it.

Safflower and Wolfberry Foot Pad for Corns (Hong Hua Di Gu Pi)

One hundred grams of safflower and one hundred grams of wolfberry root bark, ground together into a fine powder. Applied as a paste over the corn and secured with adhesive tape. Left in place for seven days to half a month.

Corns, those hard, painful nodules on the soles of the feet, were common among farmers and laborers who spent their days standing on hard earth. This was the slow, patient remedy: apply, wrap, wait, and let the paste do its work.

A single application was said to resolve the corn entirely. The herbs were typically obtained from the same medicine shop that supplied the household other dried ingredients.

Sharpleaf Galangal Fruit for Sudden Diarrhea (Yi Zhi Ren)

Sixty grams of sharpleaf galangal fruit (Yizhiren), decocted in water to make a strong, concentrated tea. Taken in one sitting.

This was a measure for a specific and alarming situation, sudden, uncontrolled abdominal distension and diarrhea that did not respond to anything else. In the vocabulary of traditional understanding, this was described as qi collapse.

This is a powerful preparation used only in extreme circumstances. It is documented here for cultural record, not for home use.

Solomons Seal for Skin Fungus (Huang Jing Xi Fang)

Thirty grams of Solomons seal (huang jing), ten grams of clove, and ten grams of Japanese Stemona Root. Boiled in water and used as an external wash on affected skin.

The herbs were simmered together, and the resulting liquid, once cooled to a tolerable temperature, was used to wash the affected areas. For foot fungus, the feet were soaked directly in the warm decoction.

Solomons seal is a common plant in traditional Chinese medicine, recognizable by its arching stems and hanging white flowers. It grows wild in many parts of China and was often collected and dried at home.

Fresh Ginger and Perilla Leaf for Wind-Cold (Zi Su Ye Sheng Jiang Tang)

Five slices of fresh ginger and about thirty grams of fresh perilla leaves (*Perillae Folium*), boiled together in water.

In Chinese folk understanding, colds are not all the same. There is wind-cold and wind-heat. Wind-cold, the kind that comes on suddenly, with chills, a scratchy throat, and clear nasal discharge, was the one this addressed.

My grandmother would go into the garden and pick perilla leaves (*Perillae Folium*), purple-backed, broad, smelling of something between mint and anise. She would slice the ginger, skin on, toss both into a pot of water, and bring it to a boil. Five minutes was enough. No sugar. No honey. Just the sharp, herbal heat.

She said the perilla pushed the cold out through the skin, and the ginger pushed it out through the stomach. Between the two of them, the cold had nowhere to hide.

Wormwood Tea for Mouth Ulcers (Yin Chen Hao Cha)

Thirty grams of dried *Artemisia capillaris* Thunb (yin chen hao), steeped in just-boiled water, covered, and left to infuse for fifteen minutes.

For mild cases, the infusion was used as a mouth rinse several times a day. For more persistent ulcers, it was drunk as a tea, three to four times daily.

Artemisia capillaris Thunb, *Artemisia capillaris* Thunb, is a close relative of mugwort. It grows wild in fields and along roadsides across China. In spring, the young shoots are collected and dried.

She picked it herself, in April, from the vacant lot behind the hutong. Dried it on a bamboo tray in the courtyard. By June, it was medicine.

Acupressure for Hiccups (Zan Zhu Xue An Ya)

A pressure-point technique: both thumbs pressed firmly against the inner edges of the eyebrows, at the point called zan zhu, where the brow meets the bridge of the nose. Pressure increased gradually until a sensation of soreness or numbness radiates.

The person with hiccups takes a deep breath and holds it for ten to fifteen seconds. While they hold, the thumb pressure is maintained. On the exhale, the pressure is released. This cycle is repeated four or five times.

My grandfather had hiccups that would not stop after a large meal. My grandmother stood behind him, found the points with her thumbs without looking, pressed until he winced, and told him to hold his breath. By the fourth cycle, the hiccups were gone.

She said the body has doors, and a hiccup is just a door that forgot to close.

Mung Bean Paste for Burns (Dou Fen Fang)

Thirty grams of mung bean powder mixed with enough egg white to form a smooth paste.

The paste was spread over the burned area and left in place. Applied two to three times a day. The egg white formed a protective film as it dried; the mung bean powder was thought to draw out the heat from the burn.

This was a first-aid measure for minor household burns, the kind you get from touching a hot wok handle or splashing boiling water. For serious burns, immediate medical attention is essential. This is cultural documentation, not a substitute for proper burn care.

Warm Liquor Rub for Leg Cramps (Bai Jiu Rou Cuo)

Before bed, soak the feet in warm water for five to ten minutes. Dry them. Heat a small amount of high-proof clear liquor, baijiu or similar, until warm. Pour a little into the palm and massage vigorously into the areas where cramps most often strike, usually the calves, until the skin reddens.

If the person drinks, a small half-shot of the same warmed liquor is taken orally before sleep. The external massage plus the internal warmth was thought to keep the muscles relaxed through the night.

My grandfathers legs cramped so badly some nights he would sit up shouting. My grandmother kept a bottle of baijiu under the bed specifically for this.

She said the liquor went in through the skin and told the muscles to be quiet.

Sichuan Peppercorn Rinse for Toothache (Hua Jiao Han Shu)

Ten grams of Sichuan peppercorns, steeped in just-boiled water for about five minutes, then mixed with fifty milliliters of clear liquor. Allowed to cool, then used as a mouth rinse.

While rinsing, the hegu point on the opposite hand is pressed firmly, a pressure point located in the webbing between the thumb and index finger.

The Sichuan peppercorn produces a numbing, tingling sensation, the same one familiar from Sichuan cuisine. Combined with the alcohol, it creates a temporary effect on the gum tissue.

She said the peppercorn numbs the tooth, and the thumb numbs the nerve that runs from the tooth to the brain. Between the two, the pain could not find its way home.

Fig Leaf Steam for Hemorrhoids (Wu Hua Guo Ye Xun Xi)

Fresh or dried fig leaves, boiled in water for half an hour, then used as a steam bath and wash for the affected area.

The hot decoction was poured into a basin. The person sat above it, allowing the steam to rise. As the liquid cooled, it was used to wash the area directly. The stems and small fruit of the fig tree, if available, were said to be even more effective.

Fig trees are common in many Chinese courtyards. In the folk tradition, every part of the fig tree was considered useful, the fruit for eating, the leaves for external washing, the white sap for treating warts.

She said the fig tree gives three things: shade in summer, fruit in autumn, and medicine all year round.

Arborvitae Tincture for Patchy Hair Loss (Ce Bai Ye Ding)

Thirty grams of fresh arborvitae leaves (ce bai ye) and ten grams of dried red chili peppers, chopped and steeped in one hundred milliliters of seventy-five percent alcohol for one week.

The resulting tincture was applied with a cotton ball to the bare patches of the scalp, three to four times a day. The alcohol dried quickly, leaving behind the herbal compounds.

Arborvitae, *Platycladus orientalis*, is a common ornamental tree in Chinese temples and gardens, recognizable by its flat, scale-like leaves arranged in vertical fans. The leaves were collected fresh and used immediately.

She picked the leaves from the tree beside the temple gate. She said the tree that grows near prayers grows stronger medicine.

Willow Leaf Wash for Athletes Foot (Liu Ye Xi Jiao)

A handful of fresh, tender willow leaves, boiled in water to make a foot soak. For infections between the toes, the raw leaves were crushed and rolled into small pellets, then tucked between the affected toes before bed.

The leaves were simmered until the water took on a pale greenish tint. The feet were soaked in the warm liquid. The raw-leaf pellets were left in place overnight, held by a pair of clean socks.

Willow leaves are at their most tender in spring. My grandmother collected them in April and used them fresh. The young leaves have a higher water content and release their compounds more readily than mature leaves.

She said the willow tree grows by water because it knows how to dry things out. A tree that understands wetness understands how to end it.